

Consider the physical space. Are you doing this at home? In public? Who else is around?

Bad: At the park with your kids running around.

Good: At home (or in a familiar and comfortable setting, like a coffee shop) where you and your partner can focus on each other.

Consider time. Is it in the morning or at night? Will it be a thirty-minute conversation or will it drag out for three hours? (My advice: Keep first conversations to one hour max. End on a high note, celebrate how far you came, and pick up the rest another day.)

Bad: Late at night when both of you are tired.

Good: After you've both had coffee and a light meal, and you have sixty minutes carved out for a good discussion.

Consider the framing of the conversation. Is this to "figure this stupid money stuff out" or to "create our Rich Life together"?

Bad: "I keep telling you to stop overspending. What is it going to take for you to finally listen?"

Good: "I love you and I want us to build toward our Rich Life. I have some ideas, but I want to hear yours too. It's really important to me that we do this together."

Be prepared for surprising reactions. The most common one is bewilderment: "Rich Life? We have bills to pay!"

Anticipate being dragged into the logistical weeds: "Fine. I'll pay our bills and you take over the groceries. The problem is that when I shop for us, you always get mad at how much I spend. So what you're saying is you want to be in charge, but you want *me* to do all the work. Is that what you want?" Anticipate this and refocus the conversation back on your Rich Life: "I want to get into specifics soon, but let's keep brainstorming. I want to really understand what *your* Rich Life looks like and what *our* Rich Life could be."

Acknowledge your own weaknesses. Your first conversation is not the place to blame your loved one for anything. Instead, start by talking about why you're bringing this up now. Be a leader by admitting how you're feeling—Nervous? Scared? Excited?—and gently ask them to share too.

Most of all, don't wait. You have everything you need to have a conversation about money right now.